



UNITED NATIONS
CORRESPONDENTS ASSOCIATION
CARTOONISTS



BACKGROUND
GUIDE

Table of Contents

Introduction of the Executive Board

Letter from the Executive Board

Introduction To The UNCA

PART A: General Guidelines

- **The Political Spectrum**
- **How to go about Research**

PART B: AGENDA

- **Introduction**
- **Timeline**
- **Aftermath of the Panama Papers**
- **Elements of the agenda**
- **Media-Related Happenings**
- **Questions to answer**

PART C: CARTOONING

- **Points to Remember**
- **Cartoon Specific Guidelines**
- **Types of Elements**
- **Types of Cartoons**

End Note

Bibliography

Letter From the Head of Cartoonists



“Draw a monster. Why is it a monster?”

~Janice Lee, Daughter

Greetings delegates!

Brought into the world with a desire for survival, humans are propelled with a quest for knowledge and an unrelenting drive to create, foundations that have forged a path for humanity from its very existence. These very qualities, of creativity and wit, also manifest themselves into a subtle subversion, a defiant upheaval or, as more commonly known, a cartoon. Political cartoons serve as reminders that artistry can seep even in the labyrinthine of human synergy. At UNCA-C, every second is a possibility to translate nuanced emotions into imagery, distil complexities of global diplomacy into humour and an opportunity to decisively validate the power of ink and strokes over war and blood.

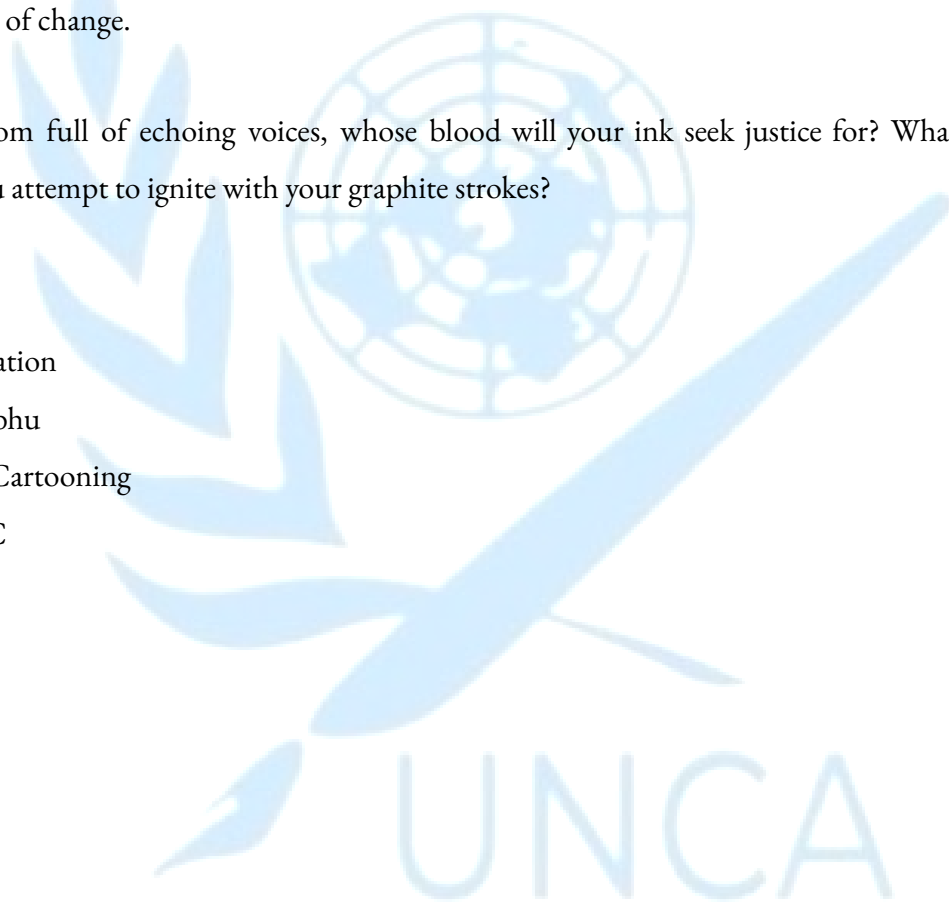
I was introduced to the profound world of MUNs in 7th grade. I remember the distinct feeling of what seemed like a nervous breakdown when I first entered the committee, the anxiety that took over when I missed the deadline by 20 minutes on my very first task and then the apprehension that

gripped me as I sought feedback from my directors. The years that have passed since, have shaped in a way I could never have anticipated and led me here.

I am Tanvi Prabhu, and it is my absolute honour and privilege to serve as the Head of Cartoonists for this edition of SMUN. Delegates, I promise you no comfort, for that would be falsehood. This committee demands you to step out of the confines of your comfort zone, to be ever on your toes and to keep a watchful eye on the ticking clock. Above all, it necessitates you to listen with acute perception and unveil the narratives that others often overlook. In this committee, you are not merely creating art; you are shaping policies. Delegates, you are architects of transformation and vanguards of change.

In the room full of echoing voices, whose blood will your ink seek justice for? What rebellion would you attempt to ignite with your graphite strokes?

In anticipation
Tanvi Prabhu
Head of Cartooning
UNCA-C



Letter From the Head of Cartoonists



Greetings Delegates!

Cartoons have always been powerful. In a world full of political speeches, long reports, draft solutions, and half-truths, they speak with simplicity and honesty. With a straight line here, a crooked one there, cartoons capture what words often cannot. However, in their simplicity lies power, and in their humour lies truth. A single illustration has the power to illuminate adversities, spark introspection, or even expose hypocrisy through satire. Cartoons are more than just mere illustrations; they are instruments of observation and interpretation.

It was this same combination of observation and interpretation that first drew me into the world of MUNs. I am Sreeparna Mitra, and I'll be serving as your Director for SMUN 2026. My journey began back in 7th grade, and since then, I have learnt many things. UNCA is a space where ideas, creativity, and chaos all come together in the best way possible. In this committee, your role won't just be that of an illustrator; it will be that of the narrators- the narrator of unspoken debates, of

ideas veiled behind perfect and crisp speeches, and of subtle truths hidden in the shadows. Because remember, in the quiet strokes of a cartoon lies the power to pierce facades, to question the unquestioned, and to reveal what might just be right in front of you; for sometimes, the most spartan image can unveil the deepest truths.

Until ink meets paper,

Sreeparna Mitra

Head of Cartooning

UNCA-C



Letter From the Additional Director of Cartoonists



“Simplicity is the ultimate sophistication”

-Leonardo Da Vinci

Greetings Delegates!

As stated by one of the greatest artisans of all time, simplicity often carries the greatest sophistication. In discourse and debate, it is the clearest idea, not the loudest one, that leaves a profound impact. This simplicity is not staying silent, but knowing what truly needs to be said. Cartooning follows this very principle of balance; neither too loud nor completely silent. Here, a single line, carefully drawn, can speak volumes without raising a voice. A single idea can change an entire narrative. In rooms filled with formal speeches, cartoons create a unique space. Through satire and symbolism, cartoonists reveal unspoken debates and truths existing beneath the surface.

Reminiscing back to my first MUN, I can still vividly recall the day my friends prompted me to fill that dreaded Google form, the 9th-grade me in a room full of people who had way more experience than I did, and my arguments that made no sense during the verbal crisis. But, somewhere between

the tasks, moderated caucuses and late-night research, I learned that MUNs are not about perfection, but rather growth. Every mistake became a lesson, and every debate became an opportunity to think deeper. MUN is about teaching the ones eager to learn, the values of adaptability, negotiation, leadership and diplomacy.

Keeping this spirit in mind, I introduce myself. I am Yehom Konwar Gogoi, and it is a privilege to serve as your Additional Director for SMUN 2026. In this committee, your role goes beyond illustration. This committee is meant to be a space where creativity meets critical thinking. I encourage you to use your art to question and challenge delegates. Remember, cartooning is not about being loud or silent; it is about being intentional and clear.

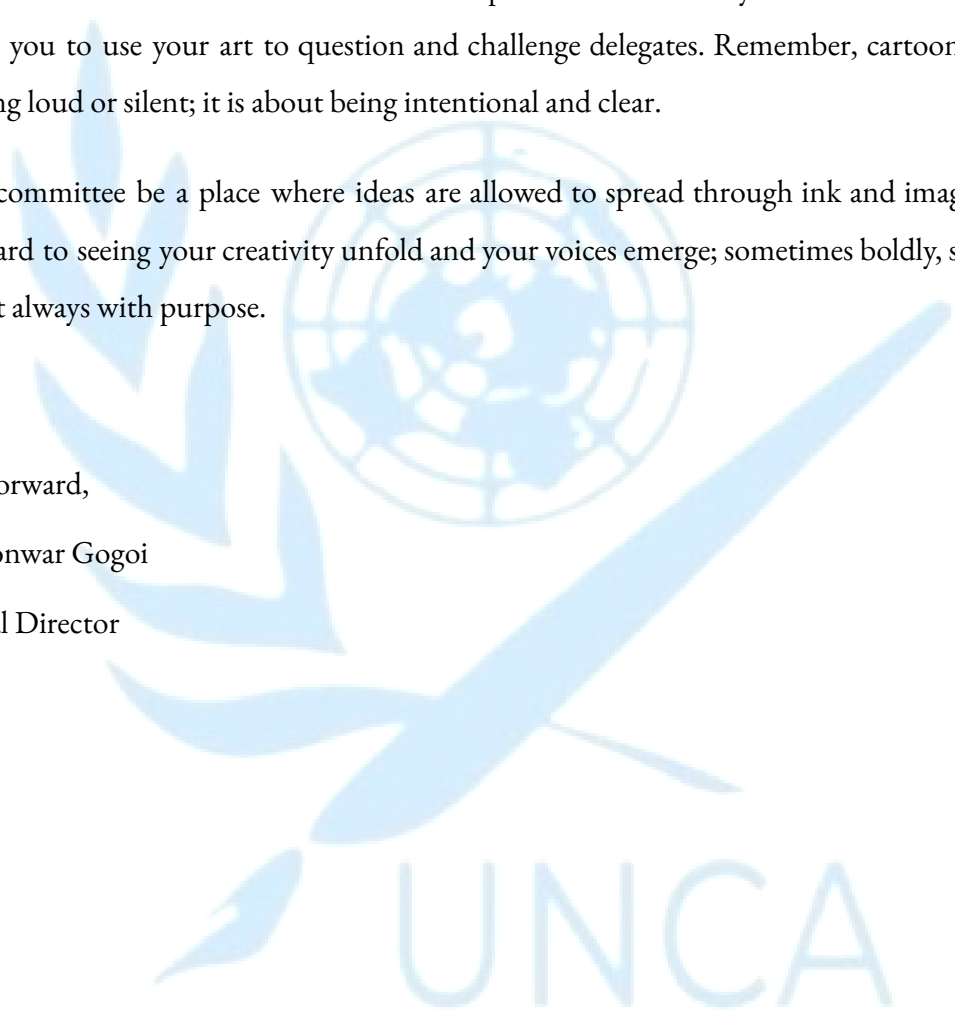
May this committee be a place where ideas are allowed to spread through ink and imagination. I look forward to seeing your creativity unfold and your voices emerge; sometimes boldly, sometimes subtly, but always with purpose.

Looking forward,

Yehom Konwar Gogoi

Additional Director

UNCA-C



Letter From the Executive Board

Dear Delegates,

It is with great anticipation that the Executive Board welcomes you to the United Nations Correspondents Association- Cartooning. Welcome to a space where every second is a possibility to translate nuanced emotions into imagery, distil complexities of global diplomacy into humour, and an opportunity to decisively validate the power of ink and strokes over war and blood.

Delegates, as you wield your quill to courageously dissect political discourse onto paper, remember that the fate of the press teeters on these very tips. You enter this committee, where its very foundations are being threatened. The agenda before you, *Deliberating on the State Retaliation and Threats to Press Freedom Faced by Journalists in the Aftermath of the Panama Papers*, is rooted in a defining rupture in modern journalism. The Panama Papers were not merely a financial exposé; it was a collective outcry of truths long buried and voices long silenced. But the machinery of power often turns against those who dare to expose it.

The committee is based precisely in this aftermath, where the very institutions tasked with protecting free expression stood complicit in its erosion. As delegates, you are entrusted with representing news agencies that operate within distinct political, economic, and ideological frameworks. Your task is not to seek artificial consensus, but to navigate competing narratives, institutional biases, and ethical dilemmas with intellectual rigour.

Journalism in this committee is not passive observation; it is active intervention. This is not an expectation or a demand; this is the need of the hour. Whether through cartoons or verbal deliberation, your work should reflect an acute awareness of the context, power dynamics and the ethical cost of each editorial decision. We look forward to witnessing the discourse you will shape and, more importantly, the questions you dare to ask.

Please do not hesitate to contact us if you have any doubts regarding the agenda, committee procedure, or just the MUN in general, by emailing us at uncac2026.smun@gmail.com

Regards,
Executive Board

Introduction to UNCA

Established in 1948, the United Nations Correspondents Association represents the UN press corps at the United Nations regarding media access and news coverage issues. A subsidiary body of the United Nations, it comprises over 200 correspondents and producers from over a dozen nations, including scores of member states, publications, news agencies and broadcasters. As a representative organisation, it strives to uphold journalistic ideals and protect the rights and privileges of the press.

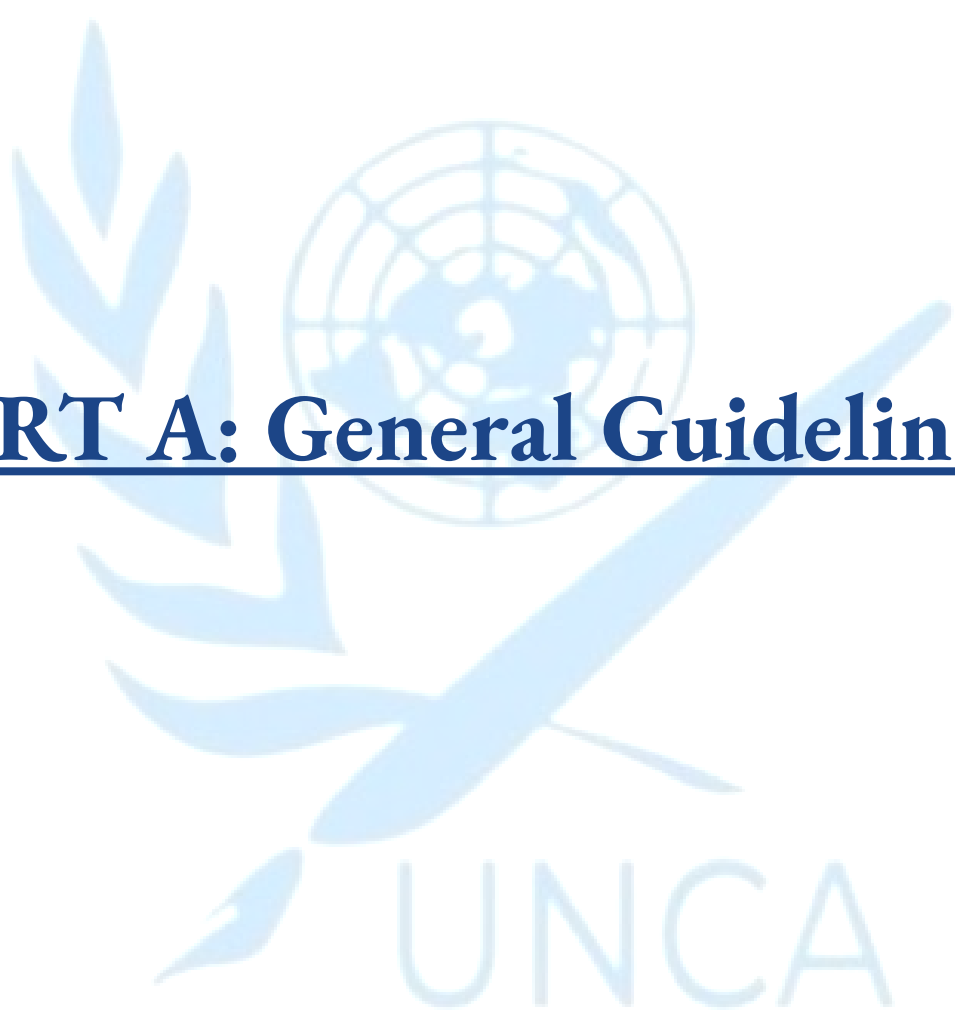
The relationship between the UNCA and the Secretary-General is based on an agreement signed on 16th November 1995 and included in the UNCA constitution. What once started off as a 50-member organisation in 1948 has come a long way since its humble beginnings. The number of members has grown significantly in accordance with the increasing role of the organisation. It unites correspondents, diplomatic delegation members, Secretariat officials, other distinguished personalities and the Department of Public Information. Now, the association champions the delivery of accurate, unbiased, and relevant reporting of occurrences at the

UN headquarters and regional offices. The UNCA draws its authority from its constitution, which stipulates a mandate and a clear code of conduct, as well as its relationship with the Secretary-General. This document represents the organisation's ideals and clarifies the several categories of membership and their tenures. The body is constituted of regular, associate, honorary and alumni members. An Executive Committee governs it, wherein the officers of the Association include a President, First, Second and Third Vice Presidents, a Secretary, a Treasurer, and nine members-at-large.

Under the Dag Hammarskjöld Memorial Scholarship Fund, the UNCA provides recognition to young journalists spread across the globe. They are provided with a stipend to tour the United Nations and report from the General Assembly. The prestigious UNCA Excellence in Journalism Awards are presented every year. The United Nations Correspondents Association is recognised each year by the General Assembly in a resolution approved under the auspices of the Committee to Review United Nations Public Information Policies and Activities, also known as The

Committee on Information. The United Nations Correspondents Association started in 2014, after a surge of violence against journalists. The statement stressed the importance of press freedom.





PART A: General Guidelines

The Political Spectrum

While researching one's agency bias, a cartoonist will inevitably come across certain labels or terms that define the agency's position on the 'left-right' political spectrum. Owing to their ambiguous nature and the fluidity in their meaning, these terms can often be misconstrued and adversely affect how a cartoonist perceives their agency's bias. This section of the background guide shall thus delve into the intricacies of various positions on the political spectrum a person might find themselves aligning with. The political terms 'left-wing' and 'right-wing' took birth in the French Revolution of 1789. The left, in this political scenario, referred to the revolutionaries who called for the abolition of the monarchy, while the right was constituted by monarchical loyalists. The terms left and right were not employed to name differing political ideologies, per se, but rather to seat proponents and opponents of the issue in a particular manner. However, today, the left and the right are distinguished by ideals that support change and uprising, and the urge to stick to the status quo, respectively.

The Left

In politics, the left refers to an umbrella of egalitarian ideologies and views purporting state control of major institutions of socio-economic life. Leftists tend to regard social welfare as the *raison d'être* of government. Left-wing politics traditionally preach a detachment from religion and support more liberal ideologies. The ideology of liberalism considers protecting and strengthening the freedom of an individual as the central matter in question. Socialism is an example of a standard left-wing ideology practised; communism, however, remains a more radical approach to leftist politics.

The Centre-Left

The centre-left refers to political ideologies and institutions that find a place on the left side of the political spectrum but inch closer to the centre than the left. Also known as the moderate left, it emphasises that the attainment of equality requires personal responsibility on the part of the individual through their abilities and talents. Centre-left ideologies generally support a mixed economy, a system of social security, government regulation of private enterprises, etc.

The Centre

Centrism is typically a political worldview that involves accommodation and an optimum balance of social equality and social hierarchy. Centrists typically avoid ideologies that would categorise them as either leftist or rightist. A news agency with a centrist 'bias' would typically be neutral to all opinions on an issue.

The Centre-Right

Refers to political ideologies and institutions that find a place on the right side of the political spectrum but inch closer to the centre than the right. Economic liberalism has influenced the economic components of the current centre-right, which generally supports free markets and limited government spending. The moderate right is neither universally socially conservative or culturally liberal, and it frequently blends both viewpoints with support for civil liberties and traditional values.

The Right

It refers to the part of the political spectrum where institutions are in favour of free enterprise and private ownership and further tend to support socially traditional hierarchies, ideas and nationalist beliefs. The ideology of nationalism believes in the unification of the state and the nation, in which case loyalty and devotion to the nation reign supreme. Right-wing politics is defined by a belief that particular social systems and hierarchies are inevitable, natural, normal, or desirable, with natural law, economics, or tradition frequently backing this perspective. In market economies, hierarchy and inequality may be considered as an inevitable outcome of traditional social distinctions or competitiveness. Right-wing politics is seen as the polar opposite of left-wing politics.

Press Conference

The main objective of each journalist is to provide the masses with the truth, enabling them to form their own unique perspectives. Press conferences serve as a platform for UNCA correspondents to voice questions from the public to those in positions of power. It helps in raising the distress of those who are often gone unheard and also tends to hold corrupt policymakers responsible for their unjust actions. This bestows upon the media the power to shape the viewpoints of billions of people all over the world, and this responsibility now lies in your hands.

At SMUN, journalists and cartoonists conduct press conferences in the committees allotted to them. The press conference usually lasts for 15-20 minutes, allowing each correspondent to ask 2-3 questions each, excluding the follow-up questions. Before the press conference, delegates are expected to devise questions based on thorough research and committee proceedings. It is advised that one prepare as many questions as possible to avoid any overlap between the questions of fellow correspondents.

The questions can be directed towards an individual delegate, a specific bloc, or the committee at large. If the question is addressed to a specific bloc or the committee at large, it is under the discretion of the UNCA Executive Board to determine who shall answer the question.

Cartoonists need to ensure that they keep their agency bias in mind while conducting press conferences; they are also expected to make a cartoon encapsulating the discourse, details for which are provided in the ‘Cartooning’ section of the background guide.

Follow-ups are highly encouraged, especially when a delegate fails to provide a satisfactory response to the question posed by the correspondent. They are also reflective of the correspondent’s research and understanding of the agenda of their allotted committee. However, pleas to follow up are granted only at the discretion of the Executive Board. Finally, the key to a successful press conference for a correspondent is confidence and composure, alongside the quality of questions posed.

How to go about Research

The fundamental responsibility of Cartoonists is to cover and communicate complex ideas through satire, symbolism and humour. Unlike traditional journalism, cartooning does not solely rely on lengthy messages but instead converts them into powerful and concise imagery. However, this does not reduce one's need for research, but rather makes it even more important. A cartoonist must carry a clear understanding of the problem at hand and an accurate understanding of the events presented.

Here are a few pointers to keep in mind while going about your research as a member of the press of the United Nations Correspondents Association:

News Agency:

A news agency is the portfolio allotted to each journalist in the UNCA. It is, in essence, the better part of one's identity as a journalist. One must be thorough with the research of their allotted news agencies, which should include their history, establishment, current status, accolades, etc.

Agency Bias:

Bias in cartoons refers to the tendency of news agencies to present issues in a way that aligns with their political, cultural, or ideological stance. When discussing the political spectrum, we're looking at the range of political opinions, from left to right (the required information is given on page 13). Every media house has its own stance and bias shaped by its ownership (private, state-owned, etc.), audience, and national interests. Political cartoons reflect the editorial bias of their news agency, using satire to express their viewpoints. Cartoonists can never contradict the bias their news agency stands for.

Background Guides

Delegates must familiarise themselves thoroughly with the background guide of the UNCA and that of the committee assigned to them. Background guides serve as the foundation for the committee's agenda, and as the terminus a quo for the research a journalist is required to undertake. It is recommended that all journalists visit websites to learn more about the agenda and

to acquire information for speeches. It is also highly suggested that every point that is presented is meticulously verified and fact-checked. It is recommended that delegates study

international relations and world politics in order to be ready for any crisis. They may also review the matrix of the committees in order to gain a better understanding of their procedures.



Part B: AGENDA



Introduction

Introduction to the agenda

The Panama Papers originated from a 2015 data leak provided by an anonymous source, self-identified as John Doe, to two journalists at the German newspaper Süddeutsche Zeitung Bastian Obermayer and Frederik Obermaier. The leaked dataset consisted of 11.5 million leaked documents from the law firm Mossack Fonseca, including emails, contracts, and financial records across several decades, tracing back to the late 1970s. This material was subsequently shared with the International Consortium of Investigative Journalism. The International Consortium of Investigative Journalism facilitated a coordinated investigation over 100 media organisations across more than 70 countries.

Shell companies

The offshore financial system, as represented in Mossack Fonseca, functioned through the incorporation and management of low-tax or no-tax jurisdictions, commonly referred to as tax havens. These shell companies are legal entities, with no significant physical presence, employees, or active business operations, but

The documents detailed the creation and operation of over 200,000 offshore entities, reflecting the scale and complexity of the financial structure across jurisdictions. The publication of this data on 3rd April 2016, gave the world what is deemed to be 'the biggest leak in the history of data journalism, raising global attention to a systematic structure of tax evasion and financial opacity. However, in the wake of the Panama Papers, journalists across the globe were reminded of the cost of deviance. Surveillance became routine, harassment and threats against journalists were orchestrated, and the very institutions tasked with protecting free expression stood complicit in its erosion.

are used to hold assets or conduct financial transactions.

The process generally involved registering a company in an offshore jurisdiction with minimal disclosure requirements, often through intermediaries such as banks, law firms, or financial advisors. To maintain confidentiality, nominee directors and

shareholders were frequently appointed, allowing the beneficial owner to remain undisclosed in public records.

Once established, these entities could be used to open bank accounts, own property, hold investments, or route financial flows across jurisdictions. A corporate shell can also be formed around a partnership to create limited liability for the partners, and other business ventures, or to immunise one part of a business from the risks of another part. By layering multiple shell companies across different jurisdictions, ownership structures could become increasingly complex, making it difficult for regulators to trace the origin and movement of funds. Mossack Fonseca facilitated the creation of 200,000 such entities. Clients could buy an anonymous company for as little as USD 1,000. However, at this price, it was just an empty shell. For an extra fee, Mossack Fonseca provided a sham director and, if desired, concealed the company's true shareholder. This resulted in the creation of an offshore company whose true purpose and ownership structure are indecipherable from the outside. While such structures can be used for legitimate purposes, including asset management and cross-border investment, their opacity has also raised concerns regarding tax avoidance, regulatory evasion, and concealment of

financial activity, particularly in contexts where oversight is limited.

These concerns have been attempted to be addressed through the United Nations Convention Against Corruption (UNCAC). The United Nations Convention Against Corruption is the only legally binding anti-corruption multilateral treaty adopted in 2003. Despite the existence of such multilateral frameworks, subsequent revelations of financial concealment and money laundering have raised questions regarding the effectiveness of their implementation. Against this backdrop of complex financial structures, the manner in which such information was accessed, analysed, and brought to public attention becomes central to understanding the significance of the investigation.

Panama Papers- Mechanisms used for Investigation

The scale of data necessitated extensive coordination and stringent security measures. Upon recognising the vastness of the data before them, Süddeutsche Zeitung collaborated with the International

Consortium of Investigative Journalists to organise research and document verification across the global network of media partners. In total, over 370 journalists from more than 100 media organisations working in nearly 25 languages participated in the investigation.

Journalists were granted controlled access to a secure, virtual newsroom, where encrypted communication systems were used to ensure confidentiality and mitigate risks associated with surveillance and data breaches. Strict protocols were implemented, including restricted data access, compartmentalisation of information, and adherence to a common publication embargo to ensure synchronised release of findings.

The dataset included approximately 4.8 million emails, 3 million database files, 2.2 million PDFs, and over 1 million images, all of which required systematic organisation. Journalists utilised advanced data-processing tools, including indexing software such as Apache Solr and content extraction frameworks like Apache Tika, to render the documents searchable. Optical character recognition (OCR) techniques were employed to convert scanned documents into machine-readable text, enabling efficient analysis.

To ensure analytical accuracy, journalists cross-referenced extracted information with external databases, public records, and financial disclosures, allowing for the verification of identities, ownership structures, and transactional linkages. The collaborative framework enabled region-specific expertise, wherein journalists with contextual knowledge of particular jurisdictions contributed to interpreting data relevant to their respective regions.

Operational security remained a critical concern throughout the process. Data was stored in secure environments, including air-gapped systems with no internet connectivity, and access was limited to authorised personnel. Communication between journalists and sources was conducted exclusively through encrypted channels, in accordance with the conditions set by the source. Additional safeguards, including controlled physical access to data storage systems and tamper-evident mechanisms, were implemented to prevent unauthorised interference. The investigation ultimately culminated in an organised global publication on 3rd April 2016, at 8 PM German standard time (Central European Time).

Timeline

1977: Founding of Mossack Fonseca

German attorney Jürgen Mossack and Panamanian attorney Ramón Fonseca founded Mossack Fonseca in Panama in 1977. The company specialises in creating offshore companies, which are companies that have their headquarters outside of their home country, usually for tax reasons. It eventually expanded to become one of the largest suppliers of these services worldwide, helping clients use offshore shell companies to evade taxes, avoid sanctions, and launder money.

1977-2015: The Growth of the Offshore Networks

From 1977 to 2015, Mossack Fonseca grew globally and operated in various locations, including the British Virgin Islands, the Bahamas, and Luxembourg. The firm set up over 200,000 shell companies for clients, which included politicians, business leaders, and celebrities. These companies were often used to secretly transfer money across borders. Most of the services provided were legal, but the documents revealed that banks, law firms and other offshore players often failed to meet legal requirements (such as

KYC) to ensure that their clients were not involved in criminal activities, tax evasion, or political corruption.

2015: The Leak by John Doe

- **Early-mid 2015:** An anonymous whistleblower, going by the pseudonym “John Doe”, began contacting investigative journalist Bastian Obermayer at the German newspaper, *Süddeutsche Zeitung*.
- About 11.5 million private documents from Mossack Fonseca were leaked by John Doe. The International Consortium of Investigative Journalists led a global investigation after receiving these files from the *Süddeutsche Zeitung*. This material included emails, contracts and records, spanning over four decades (1970s-2010s), revealing how offshore financial systems functioned and how secrecy was maintained within them.

February 2015-April 2016

Over approximately 14 months, more than 370 journalists from over 100 media

organisations across 80 countries analysed the 11.5 million documents under the investigation led by the ICIJ.

April 3, 2016: Global Publication of the Panama Papers (Freeze Date)

The Panama Papers were officially released on April 3, 2016, when the results of the ICIJ's investigation drew global attention and revealed several covert financial networks.

The investigation was made public worldwide.

The release, which exposed how wealthy individuals used offshore accounts to launder money and avoid paying taxes, involved more than 100 media outlets. The leak quickly



Aftermath of the Panama Papers

The release of the Panama Papers on April 3, 2016, triggered immediate international political consequences. This massive leak, involving over 11.5 million confidential documents from Mossack Fonseca, exposed a vast offshore financial network tied to several politicians, celebrities, and business leaders worldwide. Political figures across many nations faced scrutiny from the public, media, and investigative journalists. On April 5, 2016, the Prime Minister of Iceland, Sigmundur Davíð Gunnlaugsson, resigned after massive backlash, as his links to offshore companies were revealed. Similar political pressure could be seen in several other countries, such as Pakistan, the United Kingdom, and Russia, where prominent individuals were mentioned in the leaked files, leading to public outrage and demands for accountability.

In Pakistan, the revelations led to major legal and political crises. The leaks mentioned the offshore assets held by the family of then-Prime Minister Nawaz Sharif. After a thorough investigation, the Supreme Court of Pakistan removed Sharif from the post of

Prime Minister on July 28, 2017. This event marked one of the most significant and long-term political consequences of the Panama Papers.

The leak also led to several investigations worldwide. Governments launched inquiries into individuals and corporations mentioned in the documents. By 2021, authorities around the globe had recovered more than \$1.36 billion in fines and penalties for unpaid taxes as a result of these investigations. Financial institutions, including banks and law firms, came under heavy scrutiny for their role in facilitating these offshore services, with regulators launching investigations into their activities, such as those conducted in Hong Kong and Singapore.

Mossack Fonseca, the law firm at the heart of the scandal, faced severe legal repercussions and reputational damage. In 2016, its offices were raided by Panamanian authorities. Increasing public pressure, combined with lawsuits, caused it to announce its closure in March 2018. Investigations and court proceedings related to Mossack Fonseca and

its role in offshore activities continued in the years after the leak.

The Panama Papers had triggered various debates about financial transparency and economic reforms. Organisations like the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) advocated for stronger rules to deal with tax evasion and transparency laws. In 2017, the OECD introduced the Common Reporting Standard (CRS), requiring automatic exchange of tax-related information between countries to promote tax transparency.

Key Consequences:

1. Prosecution and Asset Seizures:

Governments and financial authorities began taking action against individuals involved in offshore financial activities. Investigations led to billions of dollars in offshore assets being frozen. Banks and tax havens, especially in

countries like Switzerland, were forced to increase compliance with financial disclosure laws.

2. Financial Transparency Reforms:

The leak pushed governments to introduce stronger financial rules and regulations, such as stronger Know Your Customer (KYC) norms and anti-tax haven laws. International banking secrecy was significantly weakened due to efforts by organisations such as the OECD.

3. Resignations and Political

Fallout: The political impact of the Panama Papers could be noticed in the removal of Prime Minister Nawaz Sharif from office in Pakistan, the resignation of Icelandic Prime Minister Sigmundur Davíð Gunnlaugsson, and the criticism faced by the Prime Minister of the United Kingdom, David Cameron.

Elements of the Agenda

The elements of the agenda are the key thematic areas to be examined. These elements are intended to guide discussions and explore the primary concerns the agenda presents before the committee.

Political Instability

The investigation revealed the link between such offshore companies and 140 politicians across 50 countries. The disclosures thus led to political consequences across jurisdictions. In many cases, public upheaval led to the resignation of the office holders and increased scrutiny towards governmental institutions. Governments felt the need to control political narrative and public image, now more than ever. Delegates must therefore examine how political vulnerability and legitimacy crises shape state behaviour toward the press, and how transparency initiatives can be achieved without disproportionately destabilising the political landscape, especially in fragile governance contexts.

State retaliation

In the aftermath of the disclosures, state responses to investigative reporting have varied considerably, with some jurisdictions initiating legal and administrative actions against journalists and media organisations involved in the publication of sensitive information. These measures have included the use of defamation laws, national security

legislation, and financial regulations to investigate, restrict, or penalise reporting activities. Reports by Reporters Without Borders and similar bodies indicate that journalists covering financial misconduct and corruption are increasingly subject to surveillance, legal intimidation, and operational restrictions, particularly in politically sensitive contexts. The distinction between lawful state regulation and retaliatory action remains central to this issue. Delegates should therefore assess the legitimacy and intent behind state measures directed at journalists.

Legal dimension

The Panama Papers raise complex legal questions concerning the interaction of domestic legal frameworks and international obligations, particularly in state responses to investigative journalism. While offshore financial activities and their misuse are largely addressed in frameworks such as the United Nations Convention against Corruption, enforcement largely remains dependent on domestic jurisdictions. In many instances, states invoke anti-terror laws against journalists, media organisations, and individual actors involved in the reporting of the Panama Papers. The application of such legislation is often broad in scope, therefore raising concerns of its use beyond its

intended purpose. This creates a point of tension between the sovereign right of the state to legislate and enforce domestic laws and its obligation under international frameworks.

Delegates must therefore examine the limits of international law in regulating state conduct, and assess how legal frameworks can prevent the misuse of anti-terrorism and related legislation while still respecting state sovereignty and ensuring the protection of journalistic activity.

Media and surveillance

The investigation into the Panama Papers relied heavily on digital tools to process approximately 11.5 million documents. However, the same technological advancements have also expanded the capacity of states to monitor, track, and intercept journalistic activity. Instances of digital surveillance, including the monitoring of communications, metadata tracking, and the use of cyber laws to access journalistic data, have raised concerns regarding the confidentiality of sources and the integrity of investigative processes. Delegates should therefore consider the extent to which surveillance practices impact press freedom, and whether adequate safeguards exist to prevent their misuse in targeting journalists.

Safety Of Journalists

In the aftermath of the Panama Papers, concerns regarding the safety of journalists intensified, particularly for those involved in exposing offshore financial networks linked to politically exposed persons and influential elites. One can see this in the case of Daphne Caruana Galizia (2017). Additionally, journalists in multiple jurisdictions reported threats, legal intimidation, surveillance, and raids on media organisations following the publication of findings. Delegates must therefore evaluate the risks faced by journalists, which have evolved in the aftermath of the leak, and consider mechanisms that can ensure their protection while maintaining accountability of powerful actors.

Media Related Happenings

Following the leak of the Panama Papers, the backwash not only uncovered the hidden financial networks and large-scale tax evasion, but also impacted journalism on a global level. Unlike traditional investigative reports, which were confined to a single newsroom or country, the Panama Papers constructed a new model of journalistic practices defined by cross-border collaboration, data-driven investigation, and coordinated publication strategies. However, despite these advancements, several restrictions were placed, and the effects of these restrictions were felt by journalists worldwide.

SLAPP Lawsuits and Legal Challenges

Journalists became victims of *Strategic Lawsuit Against Public Participation* (SLAPP), which refers to lawsuits intended to censor, intimidate, and silence critics from continuing to produce criticism and their opinions by burdening them with the cost of legal defence. Wealthy individuals, corporations, and political figures used these lawsuits to discourage journalists from further investigating and issuing

publications. These lawsuits hit the smaller news organisations and independent journalists as they lacked the resources to fight against the legal defence.

Three years after the leak, Netflix released *The Laundromat*, a film by Steven Soderbergh that portrayed the leak dramatically and exaggeratedly. A few weeks later, Mossack Fonseca and its co-founders, Jürgen Mossack and Ramón Fonseca, who were played by Gary Oldman and Antonio Banderas in the movie, portrayed them as ***“ruthless, uncaring lawyers who are involved in money laundering, tax evasion, bribery and/or other criminal conduct,”*** sued Netflix.

Netflix asked the court to dismiss the case using California’s anti-SLAPP law. Netflix argued that the film was made due to the public interest and focused on well-known global figures and financial practices.

Media Backlash

Journalists faced significant and immediate backlash after the leak, especially in those

countries where there exists limited press freedom. According to the Global Investigative Journalism Network (GIJN), reporting on corruption exposed journalists to a wide variety of risks.

The director of Niger's *L'Événement* newspaper, Moussa Aksar, published the July 25th (2016) edition, which featured the incident, highlighting previously unknown details of an offshore company linked to a wealthy businessman who identified as a major financier of Niger's ruling political party. Rumours rapidly spread about Aksar and that he was wanted by the police for his reporting, and he went into hiding. Aksar's account is just one out of many documented as well as undocumented news outlets and journalists who have been hit with the consequences in response to their work on the investigations of the Panama Papers.

Another incident highlights how the workers at a daily newspaper, La Prensa, in Panama, were threatened by anonymous Twitter users.

"What does it feel like to destroy your country?" one of them asked. Another tweet liked and commented on by Ramon Fonseca featured a photo of the employees working at La Prensa. The comment read: ***"This is an***

act of high treason to the country to which they were born."

Journalists were threatened, raided, news outlets were brought down, they faced lawsuits, and surveillance of reporters and their sources increased. Journalists were often subjected to harassment and, in some instances, detention or questioning by authorities. In many regions, this resulted in self-censorship. While the Panama Papers strengthened investigative journalism, it also augmented the challenges faced by those working to expose corruption.

Digital Transparency

On **May 9th, 2016**, *The International Consortium of Investigative Journalists* (ICIJ) announced the release of a searchable database that released information on nearly 2,14,000 offshore entities, providing a forum of investigative tools for journalists and the public. The availability of this data significantly expanded the scope of investigative journalists. However, the release is not fully transparent as it does not include the totality of the leak and does not disclose raw documents or personal information. The emphasis shifted from simply publishing articles and stories to providing access to actual data buried under the soil.

Questions to Answer

Delegates must consider how the international community should respond to the widespread use of offshore financial networks revealed by the Panama Papers.

- What actions can media organisations take to promote transparency in reporting on global financial transactions while operating under legal and political pressure?
- To what extent should offshore financial centres be regulated, and how can stricter supervision be implemented without disturbing global finance?
- How should the committee address the role of media organisations in exposing the actions of banks, law firms and other financial intermediaries who facilitated such networks?
- How should governments deal with individuals and corporations named in the leak?
- Should there be stronger systems for proper information sharing between media organisations, and how can international collaboration help prevent suppression by the state?
- How can governments rebuild public trust after such revelations?
- What steps can be taken to hold public officials more accountable?
- How should whistleblowers and media organisations be protected in situations where governments attempt to silence them?
- What changes can media organisations implement to safely handle and report large-scale leaks in the future?

Part C: Cartooning



Points to Remember

1. Research is of utmost importance.
Delegates must be well-researched about their assigned news agency, as well as their committee's agenda. Background guides are undoubtedly the best place to start your research, but you must go beyond them to be well-versed in matters.
2. Delegates must ensure that all information mentioned in the cartoon is accurate. It is vital that a cartoon navigates through themes of exaggeration and humour while simultaneously serving as an effective medium for conveying news. To avoid misinformation, you may clarify a delegate's stance or statement through chits.
3. Plagiarism of any form is strictly prohibited and will lead to immediate disqualification. A cartoonist's individuality is shaped by their unique style, whether through exaggerating certain features or using a particular signature element. Therefore, as a cartoonist, you must harness your own individuality.
4. Digital art is not permitted for any task, except miscellaneous submissions.
5. Delegates must bring their own stationery. Only paper will be provided.
6. Deadlines must be met. Late submissions will be looked upon poorly, and no submission will lead to negative marking. Timeliness is essential, and failure to comply will not be overlooked.
7. Rules of Procedure must be followed throughout the conference. Roll call will be taken at the beginning of the committee everyday. Other ROPs to keep in mind are Motion to Open Debate, Provisional Speakers' List, Unmoderated Caucus, Round Robin, Points of Personal Privilege, Parliamentary Inquiry, and Information.
8. Cartoonists have to ensure that they keep in mind their agency bias at all times. Bias in cartoons refers to the tendency of news agencies to present issues in a way that aligns with their political, cultural, or ideological stance.

Every media house has its own stance and bias shaped by its ownership (private, state-owned, etc.), audience, and national interests. Political cartoons reflect the editorial bias of their news agency, using satire to express their viewpoints. Cartoonists can never contradict the bias their news agency stands for.

9. Fellow delegates and members of the Executive Board have to be treated respectfully. It is paramount that the cartoonist portrays only the portfolio, and not the delegates themselves, in their cartoon.

10. If there are any doubts or clarifications needed after the release of the background guide till the beginning of the conference, you can reach out to us at

uncac2026.smun@gmail.com



Cartoon Specific Guidelines

1. All cartoons must be drawn in a box.

The delegate must ensure that their name, the sub-committee's names and their new agency are written right beneath the box in which the cartoon has been drawn.

For example: Sreeparna Mitra, Fox News, UNSC

Every cartoon should have a caption which should not be more than 10 words.

2. Delegates must ensure that the message conveyed through their cartoon is coherent and readily comprehensible. The portrayal of ideas should be concise yet impactful. A degree of exaggeration in expression, symbolism, or visual elements is permissible to enhance recognisability and resonance. However, such artistic liberties must remain within the bounds of professionalism, decorum, and intellectual integrity, ensuring that the cartoon reflects both creativity and sophistication in equal measure.

3. Incorporating elements such as symbolism, irony, and exaggeration can significantly elevate the intellectual and artistic calibre of a cartoon. Nevertheless, the excessive inclusion may obscure the intended narrative, leaving the piece visually congested and conceptually fragmented.

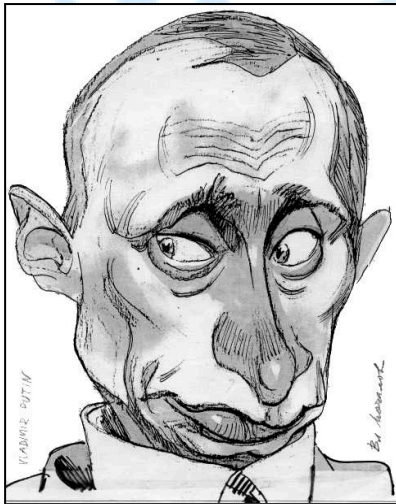
4. There exists a delicate distinction between artistic exaggeration and deliberate misrepresentation. Delegates must remain mindful of this boundary and ensure that their cartoons are grounded in factual accuracy and journalistic integrity.

5. Keep in mind :
 - Creativity
 - Originality
 - Punctuality
 - Use of Elements
 - Neatness
 - Adherence to the task

Types Of Elements

1. EXAGGERATION

Exaggeration refers to amplifying certain features in a cartoon, including not only facial features, but also events that have taken place. Exaggeration aids in making elements more recognisable, as well as more relatable.



2. SYMBOLISM

Using people (allegories), animals or objects to symbolise, or represent something complex for simplicity, as well as adding a creative element to your cartoon, is known as symbolism.



For example, Lady Justice is always seen blindfolded, to show that law does not discriminate; crows can be used to portray malintent.

3. UNDERTONES

Undertones are the themes of one's work. Undertones are determined by a plethora of factors, including the ownership of the agency the cartoonist is allotted to, the political alignment of their agency, etc. While admitting to having a bias takes away from the substance of the cartoon, the delegate must not go against the bias of the agency. For example, a government-owned agency cannot publish a cartoon with anti-government undertones.

4. IRONY

Irony showcases the opposite of the literal meaning, often used for comical effect. It highlights the contrast between what is said and what is actually done. This gap often aids in adding an element of humour and satire in the cartoon.



5. ANALOGY

This refers to the comparison of two concepts which are seemingly unrelated, but have something in common. Comparison of something simplistic and present in everyday life with a political affair is often seen in a political cartoon. Comparison can also be made based on the difference between idealism and pragmatism. For example, Newton and the apple can be used to emphasise the 'gravity' of a situation.



6. LABELLING

Labelling can be incorporated into your cartoons to make it easier for the viewer to interpret your cartoon. Labels can be in the form of catchy captions and headings, or speech bubbles.

7. SHADING AND CONTRAST

Shading is extremely important and is a major element that can make or break a cartoon. It adds a sense of depth and light and highlights aspects of a cartoon. Overuse of shading may result in your cartoon looking untidy, so ensure that you observe different political cartoons and practise shading to get the gist of it.



Types Of Cartoons

1. PRE CONFERENCE TASK

As the name suggests, this cartoon is to be submitted before the commencement of the conference. It must encapsulate the news agency's editorial stance on the committee's agenda. In essence, the cartoon serves as a visual position paper. Delegates are expected to convey a creative yet analytical expression of the agency's ideological leanings, policy perspective, and bias.

Submissions must be mailed to uncac2026.smun@gmail.com by 11:59 PM IST, 18 April 2026.

Please note that late submissions will be looked upon unfavourably.

2. ILLUSTRATIVE

This cartoon is a visual representation of a concept. With little to no text, these are usually colourful and are associated with a typical political gag. Vital significance is attributed to the cartoonist's ability to translate ideas into imagery and skillfully incorporate symbolism into their cartoons.



3. OBJECT-BASED

Cartoonists will be assigned an object that must be creatively woven into their cartoon. As with all other cartoon types, this must be centred around the unfolding of committee

proceedings. However, at the same time, the object should be prominent, serving as the central element of the cartoon.



4. CARICATURES

This cartoon type serves as an ‘exaggerated portrait’ of an individual. The objective is to make the individuals in the cartoon recognisable, without an overreliance on too many labels. Accentuating certain facial features or expressions to add a comical effect is a good way to go about making this cartoon. Cartoonists must portray only the delegate’s portfolio, and not the delegate themselves.



5. COMIC STRIP

This cartoon has multiple panels, usually ranging from two to six, depicting a scene. These are usually text-heavy, with each panel having two to three lines of captioning and considerable amounts of labelling. The comic strip must result in a conclusion, providing a closure for the scene depicted.

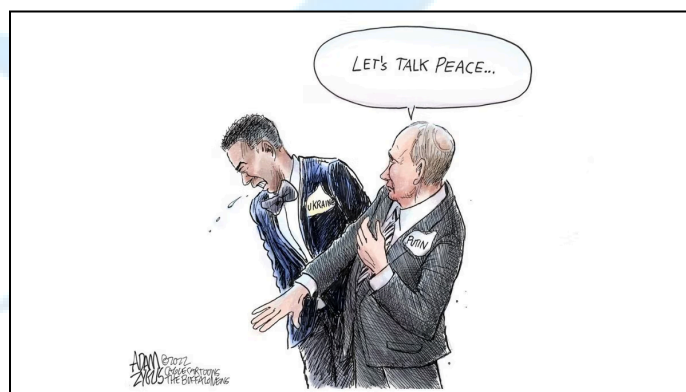


6. COLLABORATIVES

Cartoonists have the opportunity to collaborate with journalists and photographers to make a cartoon based on an article or photograph, or vice versa. One must ensure that the journalist or photographer belongs to your news agency, or an agency with the same political leanings as the delegate's assigned news agency.

7. MEME-IT-UP

One of the most anticipated cartoons at SMUN, here a cartoonist is required to make a cartoon on their committee agenda in the format of a popular meme. At the same time, one must not breach the formal nature of SMUN.



8. PERSPECTIVE CARTOON

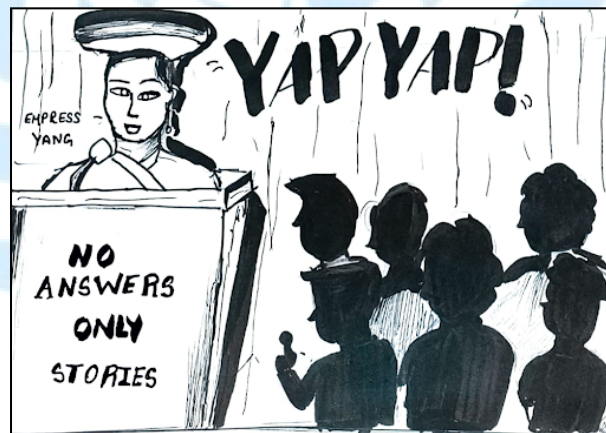
In all other cartoon formats, delegates are expected to represent the perspective of their assigned news agency. However, for this particular cartoon, the task is to illustrate the event or action from an opposing ideological standpoint. For instance, if a news agency ordinarily

endorses a specific course of action undertaken by a delegate in committee, this cartoon should depict that same action through a critical and dissenting lens.



9. PRESS CONFERENCE CARTOON

As elaborated in Section A, journalists and cartoonists will be conducting a Press Conference in their assigned committee. After doing so, cartoonists will be tasked to make a cartoon depicting the riveting exchange of dialogue between themselves and the delegates they questioned.



10. MISCELLANEOUS

This task is non-obligatory in nature. It can be any cartoon type, and does not need to be based on the committee agenda; you may address any topical issue through this cartoon. Kindly note that miscellaneous cartoons will not be published in the newsletter and will be published exclusively on the UNCA blog. However, miscellaneous submissions will be looked upon extremely favourably. This is the only task that **accepts digital cartoons**. Submissions can be mailed to uncac2026.smun@gmail.com

End Note

Delegates,

As you near the end of this guide, you are on the verge of entering a committee that demands more than watching. It requires understanding and courage. We hope this document helped you navigate the financial networks exposed by the Panama Papers, how the leak happened and the consequences for governments, organisations, and especially the media.

The information you've read shows the world before the Panama Papers leak events, leading up to April 3 2016, and what happened after. The truth is out. The effects are still felt worldwide. It's a moment caught between reaction and revelation. Your committee discussions should focus on the conflicts outlined in this guide, including those between journalism and government control, openness and power and the law. Always keep your role and perspective in mind.

Do ensure you go through the three most important aspects of this document. The first is the Timeline, which strengthens your understanding and gives you clarity about how the crisis unfolded. Second, the Elements of the Agenda, which emphasise the issue's multifaceted nature. The third is the Cartooning Section, which is more than just a set of guidelines; it's a framework which will guide you through the various tasks which will be presented in committee.

In this committee, your role goes beyond that of a delegate. You are the interpreters of truth, not just reporters of events. You are the translators and interpreters of political speeches; your cartoons serve as the arguments and the criticisms. In this committee, you have the responsibility to uphold the truth and stand by it.

You now bear the responsibility as the world struggles with the repercussions from the truths that are revealed. Do not confine yourselves to the contents of this background guide, but let it serve as your foundation.

If you have any queries, feel free to reach out to us at uncac2026.smun@gmail.com.

Yours Truly,
The Executive Board

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